



A checklist for a good “About Us” page

What is your news outlet’s mission? What communities do you cover, and how long have you been in business? What do you value, and what are your standards? Who works in your newsroom, and how are they reachable? How do you make money? These are all basic questions people might have about your news organization, but could they easily find the answers on your website, in your paper or on your social media profiles?

At Trusting News we find that a lot of newsrooms have information answering these questions somewhere, but it’s not always easy to find—and it’s almost always written using journalism jargon. Here are four steps to an effective “About Us” page.

1. Do a content audit.

What do you already have published on your website, on your social profiles or elsewhere?

- ☐ Mission statement and values
- ☐ Ethics and accuracy policies
- ☐ Ownership and funding
- ☐ History
- ☐ Staff list
- ☐ Submission instructions (for story tips, corrections, breaking news photos, etc.)
- ☐ Contact information (for each department -- news and business? In a way people can navigate if they just want to ask a question or share an idea?)

Then ask:

- ☐ Is the information still accurate?
- ☐ Does it reflect the current values and mission of the newsroom?
- ☐ When might it need to be updated, and who is in charge of doing it?
- ☐ What will it take to bring it all together in one spot?

2. Share your history, mission and values

Telling your users how long you have been reporting on what’s happening in your community can be powerful. It can also help lend credibility to your organization. Think about including:

- ☐ Your founding, other big moments in company history (ownership changes for example)
- ☐ Big changes in coverage areas and products
- ☐ Notable community involvement, sponsorships and partnerships
- ☐ Awards
- ☐ Big stories you've seen your community through, with newsroom photos

Whether you have a long history or not, you should talk about what role you serve in your community and what you value. Make sure people can find your mission statement, and also describe how it plays out in day-to-day coverage.

3. Share your ethics and corrections policies

You most likely already have newsroom policies. You probably reviewed them during one of your first days on the job. Maybe you still refer to them while writing or editing a story or responding to a user complaint. Newsroom policies often cover things like:

- ☐ Corrections and accuracy
- ☐ Financial independence
- ☐ Political independence
- ☐ Commitment to diversity
- ☐ Photo and video editing and ethics
- ☐ Conflicts of interest

Too often, these policies are invisible to users, who [do not give us automatic credit for the ethical decisions we make](#). Discuss in the newsroom what you can make public, even if that includes shortened or partial policies.

4. Create a “Contact Us” page

Finding contact information for a news organization and for individual journalists should not be complicated. All of us should have a “Contact Us” page that quickly offers information about:

- ☐ How to submit a news tip or a correction request
- ☐ How to contact a specific newsroom department/journalist
- ☐ Who to ask about delivery of your product (subscriptions, your mobile app, your website)
- ☐ Who to ask about community sponsorships or placing an ad

Remember that people might come with a task in mind (who can cover an event I'm hosting) or a specific journalist in mind (can I talk with the person who interviewed me). Make both possible.

Newsroom staff bios can also lend credibility. Users should be able to find a description of what each person does and their contact information. Consider also including more biographical information and a photo.